remarkably dynamic one. Hence, L.S. Amery in his book *Thoughts on the Constitution* says that the British Constitution is 'a blend of formal law, precedent and tradition'.

The various elements or sources of the British Constitution are explained as follows:

(i) Conventions: Conventions constitute a major element of the British Constitution. These are the unwritten principles of political practices and customary principles of constitutional behaviour which have developed in the course of time. J.S. Mill described them as the 'Unwritten maxims of the Constitution'. However, unlike the laws, they are not recognised and enforced by judicial courts. But they play a very significant role in the actual working of the British political institutions. They are generally observed as they are backed by tradition and public opinion. The well-known conventions in Britain are:

(a) The King or Queen should exercise his/her legal powers on the advise of the Cabinet headed by the Prime Minister.

(b) The King or Queen should appoint the leader of the majority party in the House of Commons as the Prime Minister.

(c) The King or Queen should dissolve the lower House of Parliament on the advise of the Prime Minister.

(d) The King or Queen should give his/her assent to all the Bills passed by the Parliament.

(e) The Cabinet is collectively responsible to the House of Commons.

(ii) Great Charters: These are also called constitutional charters or constitutional landmarks. They are historical documents which define the powers of the Crown and liberties of the citizens, and so on. They have a significant bearing on some of the basic aspects of the British Constitution. The important among such charters are the Magna Carta (1215), the Petition of Rights (1628), the Bill of Rights (1689), and others.

(iii) Statutes: These are the laws made by the British Parliament from time to time. They define and regulate the principles, structures and functions of many British political institutions. The important statutes in Britain are the Habeas Corpus Act, 1679, the Statute of Westminster, 1931, Ministers of the Crown Act, 1937, the People's Representation Act, 1948, and others.

(iv) Common Law: It is a body of judge-made laws. It has defined some of the significant rules and principles pertaining to the powers of the Government and its relationship with the citizens. They are accepted and enforced by judicial courts. Dr. Ogg defines common law as 'the vast body of legal precept and usage, which through the centuries has acquired binding and almost immutable character'.

(v) Legal Commentaries: These are the commentaries or text books written on the constitutional law of the country by the constitutional experts. They provide insight into the working of the British political institutions. They clarify the meaning and fix the scope of certain constitutional principles. Some of the popular legal commentaries on the British Constitution, are A.V. Dicey's 'Law of the Constitution', Bagehot's 'English Constitution', Blackstone's 'Commentaries on the Laws of England', and others.

2. Flexible Constitution Unlike the American Constitution, the British Constitution is flexible in nature. It requires no special procedure for its amendment. It can be amended by the Parliament in the same manner as the ordinary laws are made. Thus, in Great Britain, there exists no distinction between the constitutional law and the ordinary law.